POETRY

The flower and the leaf

Unknown

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[Illustration]

THE FLOWER AND THE LEAF.

[letter: W] When that Phebus his chaire of gold so hie [leaf] Hadde whirled up the sterrie sky alofte, [leaf] And in the Boole was entred certainely: [leaf] When shoures sweet of raine discended softe, [leaf] Causing the ground, fele times & ofte, [leaf] Up for to give many an wholesome aire, [leaf] And every plaine was eke yclothed faire

[letter: W] With newe green, and maketh smalle floures [leaf] To springen here and there in field & mede; [leaf] So very good & wholsome be the shoures, [leaf] That it renueth that was old and dede [leaf] In winter time; and out of every sede [leaf] Springeth the hearbe, so that every wight [leaf] Of this season wexeth ful glad and light.

[letter: A] And I, so glad of the season thus swete, [leaf] Was happed thus upon a certaine nighte: [leaf] As I lay in my bed, sleepe ful unmete [leaf] Was unto me, but why that I ne mighte [leaf] Rest, I ne wiste; for there nas earthly wight, [leaf] As I suppose, hadde more heartes ease [leaf] Than I, for I nadde sicknesse nor disease.

[letter: W] Wherefore I mervaile greatly of myselfe, [leaf] That I withouten sleepe so longe lay; [leaf] And up I rose three houres after twelfe, [leaf] Aboute the springing of the day, [leaf] And on I putte my geare and mine array, [leaf] And to a pleasaunt grove I gan to passe, [leaf] Long or the brighte Sonne uprisen was;

[letter: I] In which were okes great, streight as a line, [leaf] Under the which the grasse, so fresh of hewe, [leaf] Was newly sprong; and an eight foot or nine [leaf] Every tree well fro his fellow grew, [leaf] With branches brode, lade with leves newe, [leaf] That sprongen out ayen the sunne shene, [leaf] Some very red and some a glad light grene;

[letter: W] Which, as me thoughte, was right a plesant sight; [leaf] And eke the briddes songes for to here [leaf] Would have rejoiced any earthly wight; [leaf] And I, that couthe not yet, in no manere, [leaf] Heare the nightingale of all the year, [leaf] Ful busily herkened with hart & eare, [leaf] If I her voice perceive coud any where.

[letter: A] And, at the last, a path of little breede [leaf] I found, that greatly hadde not used be; [leaf] For it forgrowen was with grasse & weede, [leaf] That well unneth a wight ne might it se: [leaf] Thoght I, ‘This path some whider goth, pardé!’ [leaf] And so I followede, till it me broughte [leaf] To right a pleasaunt herber, well ywrought,

[letter: T] That benched was, & eke with turfes new [leaf] Freshly turved, whereof the grene gras, [leaf] So small, so thicke, so short, so fresh of hewe, [leaf] That most ylike greene wool, I wot, it was: [leaf] The hegge also that yede in this compas, [leaf] And closed in all the green herbere, [leaf] With sicamour was set and eglatere,

[letter: W] Wrethen in fere so well and cunningly, [leaf] That every branch & leafe grew by mesure, [leaf] Plaine as a bord, of oon height by & by. [leaf] I ne segh never thing, I you ensure, [leaf] So well y-done; for he that tooke the cure [leaf] It for to make, Y trow did all his peine [leaf] To make it passe alle tho that men have seine.

[letter: A] And shapen was this herber, roofe and all, [leaf] As is a prety parlour; & also [leaf] The hegge as thicke as is a castle wall, [leaf] That who that list withoute to stond or go, [leaf] Though he would all day prien to and fro, [leaf] He shoulde not see if there were any wighte [leaf] Within or no; but one within wel mighte.

[letter: P] Perceive Alle tho that yeden there withoute [leaf] Into the field, that was on every side [leaf] Covered with corne & grasse; that out of doubt, [leaf] Though one woulde seeke all the worlde wide, [leaf] So rich a fielde ne coude not be espide [leaf] On any coast, as of the quantitie; [leaf] For of alle good thing there was plentie.

[letter: A] And I that all this pleasaunt sight ay sie, [leaf] Thought sodainly I felte so sweete an aire [leaf] Com of the eglentere, that certainely [leaf] There is no heart, I deme, in such dispaire, [leaf] Ne with no thoughtes froward and contraire [leaf] So overlaid, but it shoulde soone have bote, [leaf] If it had ones felt this savour sote.

[letter: A] And as I stood & cast aside mine eie, [leaf] I was of ware the fairest medler tree, [leaf] That ever yet in all my life I sie, [leaf] As full of blossomes as it mighte be; [leaf] Therein a goldfinch leaping pretile [leaf] Fro bough to bough; and, as him list, gan eete [leaf] Of buddes here and there and floures sweete.

[letter: A] And to the herber side ther was joyninge [leaf] This faire tree, of which I have you told; [leaf] And at the last the brid began to singe, [leaf] When he had eaten what he eate wolde, [leaf] So passing sweetly, that by manifolde [leaf] It was more pleasaunt than I coude devise. [leaf] And when his song was ended in this wise,

[letter: T] The nightingale with so mery a note [leaf] Answered him, that all the woode rong [leaf] So sodainly, that, as it were a sote, [leaf] I stood astonied; so was I with the song [leaf] Thorow ravished, that till late and longe, [leaf] Ne wist I in what place I was, ne where; [leaf] And ay, me thoughte, she song even by mine ere.

[letter: W] Wherefore about I waited busily, [leaf] On every side, if that I her mighte see; [leaf] And, at the last, I gan full well aspie [leaf] Where she sat in a fresh grene laurer tree, [leaf] On the further side, even right by me, [leaf] That gave so passing a delicious smell, [leaf] According to the eglentere full well.

[letter: W] Whereof I hadde so inly great pleasure, [leaf] That, as me thought, I surely ravished was [leaf] Into Paradice, where as my desire [leaf] Was for to be, and no ferther to passe [leaf] As for that day; and on the sote grasse [leaf] I sat me downe; for, as for mine entent, [leaf] The birddes song was more convenient,

[letter: A] And more pleasaunt to me by many fold, [leaf] Than meat or drinke, or any other thing. [leaf] Therto the herber was so fresh and cold, [leaf] The wholesome savours eke so comforting, [leaf] That, as I demede, sith the beginning [leaf] Of thilke world was never seene or than [leaf] So pleasaunt a ground of none earthly man.

[letter: A] And as I sat, the birddes harkening thus, [leaf] Me thoughte that I hearde voices sodainly, [leaf] The most sweetest & most delicious [leaf] That ever any wight, I trow truly, [leaf] Heard in here life; for sothe the armony [leaf] And sweet accord was in so good musike, [leaf] That the voices to angels most was like.

[letter: A] And at the last, out of a grove faste by, [leaf] That was right goodly & pleasant to sight, [leaf] I sie where there came, singing lustily, [leaf] A world of ladies; but, to tell aright [leaf] Here grete beautie, it lieth not in my might, [leaf] Ne here array; neverthelesse I shalle [leaf] Telle you a part, though I speake not of alle.

[letter: T] The surcotes white, of velvet wele sitting, [leaf] They were in clad, & the semes echone, [leaf] As it were a maner garnishing, [leaf] Was set with emeraudes, one and one. [leaf] But by and by ful many a riche stone [leaf] Was set on the purfiles, out of doute, [leaf] Of colors, sleves, and traines round aboute.

[letter: A] As greate pearles, round & oriente, [leaf] Diamondes fine, and rubies rede [leaf] And many another stone, of which I wente [leaf] The names now; and everich on her heade [leaf] A riche fret of gold, which, withoute dreade, [leaf] Was full of stately riche stones set; [leaf] And every lady had a chapelet.

[letter: U] Upon her head of floures fresh and greene [leaf] So wele ywrought & so mervellously, [leaf] That soth it was a noble sight to seene; [leaf] Some of laurer, and some full pleasantly [leaf] Hadde chapelets of woodbind, and sadly [leaf] Some of agnus castus were also [leaf] Chapelets freshe; but there were many tho

[letter: T] That song & daunced, ekeful soberly, [leaf] And all they yede in manner of compace; [leaf] But one there yede in mid the company, [leaf] Soole by herselfe; but alle followede the pace [leaf] Which that she kepte, whose heavenely faire face [leaf] So pleasaunt was, and her wele shape person, [leaf] That of beautie she past hem everichone.

[letter: A] And more richly beseene, by manifold, [leaf] She was also in every maner thing: [leaf] Upon her head, full pleasaunt to beholde, [leaf] A crowne of gold riche for any kinge: [leaf] A braunch of agnus castus eke bearing [leaf] In her hand; and to my sight truly, [leaf] She lady was of al the company.

[letter: A] And she began a roundell lustely, [leaf] That ‘Suse le foyle, devers moy,’ men calle, [leaf] ‘Seen et mon joly cuer est endormy;’ [leaf] And than the company answered alle, [leaf] With voices sweet entuned, and so smalle [leaf] That it me thoughte the sweetest melody [leaf] That ever I heard in my life soothly.

[letter: A] And thus they came, dauncing & singing [leaf] Into the middest of the mede echone, [leaf] Before the herber where I was sitting; [leaf] And, God wot, me thought I was wel bigone; [leaf] For then I might avise hem one by one, [leaf] Who fairest was, who coude best dance or singe, [leaf] Or who most womanly was in alle thinge.

[letter: T] They hadde not daunced but a little throwe, [leaf] When that I hearde not ferre off sodainely, [leaf] So great a noise of thundering trumpes blow, [leaf] As though it should have departed the skie; [leaf] And, after that, within a while I sie, [leaf] From the same grove where the ladies come oute, [leaf] Of men of armes coming such a route,

[letter: A] As alle the men on earth hadde ben assembled [leaf] In that place, wele horsed for the nones, [leaf] Stering so faste, that al the earth trembled: [leaf] But for to speake of riches and of stones, [leaf] And men and horse, I trow the large wones

[leaf] Of Prestir John, ne all his tresorie, [leaf] Mighte not unneth have boght the tenth partie

[letter: O] Of here array: who so list heare more, [leaf] I shall rehearse so as I can a lite. [leaf] Out of the grove, that I of spake before, [leaf] I sie come first, all in here clokes white, [leaf] A company, that ware, for here delite, [leaf] Chapelets fresh of okes serialle, [leaf] Newly yspronge, and trumpets they were alle.

[letter: O] On every trumpe hanging a broad banere [leaf] Of fine tartarium ful richely bete; [leaf] Every trumpet his lordes armes bere; [leaf] About here neckes, with greate pearles sete, [leaf] Colleres brode; for cost they woulde not lete, [leaf] As it woulde seeme, for here scochones echone [leaf] Were set aboute with many a precious stone.

[letter: H] Here horse harneis was all white also. [leaf] And after hem next, in one company, [leaf] Came kinges of armes, & no mo, [leaf] In clokes of white cloth of gold richly; [leaf] Chapelets of greene on here heades on hie; [leaf] The crownes that they on here scochones bere, [leaf] Were set with pearle, ruby, and saphere,

[letter: A] And eke great diamondes many one: [leaf] But all here horse harneis & other geare [leaf] Was in a sute accordinge, everychone, [leaf] As ye have heard the foresaid trumpets were; [leaf] And, by seeming, they were nothing to lere, [leaf] And here guiding they dide so manerly. [leaf] And, after hem, came a great company

[letter: O] Of heraudes and pursevauntes eke, [leaf] Arrayed in clothes of whit velvette, [leaf] And, hardily, they were no thing to seke, [leaf] How they on hem shoulde the harneis sette; [leaf] And every man had on a chapelet; [leaf] Scochones and eke horse harneis, indede, [leaf] They had in sute of hem that before hem yede.

[letter: N] Next after hem camen, in armour bright [leaf] All save here heades, seemely knightes nine; [leaf] And every claspe and naile, as to my sight, [leaf] Of here harneis were of red golde fine; [leaf] With cloth of gold, and furred with ermine [leaf] Were the trappores of here stedes strong, [leaf] Wide and large, that to the ground dide honge.

[letter: A] And every bosse of bridle & paitrell [leaf] That hadde they, was worth, as I woulde wene, [leaf] A thousand pound; and on here heades, well [leaf] Dressed, were crowns of laurer grene, [leaf] The best ymade that ever I hadde sene; [leaf] And every knight had after him riding [leaf] Three henshemen on him ay awaiting.

[letter: O] Of which every first, on a short tronchoun, [leaf] His lordes helme bare, so richly dight, [leaf] That the worst was worth the ransoun [leaf] Of any king; the second a shield bright [leaf] Bare at his backe; the thridde bare upright [leaf] A mightie spere, full sharpe yground and kene, [leaf] And every child eke ware of leaves grene

[letter: A] A fresh chapelet upon his haires brighte: [leaf] And clokes white of fine velvet they were; [leaf] Here steedes trapped & arraied righte, [leaf] Withoute difference, as here lordes were; [leaf] And after hem, on many a fresh corsere, [leaf] There came of armede knightes such a route, [leaf] That they bespradde the large field aboute.

[letter: A] And all they ware, after here degrees, [leaf] Chapelets newe made of laurer grene; [leaf] Some of the oke, and some of other trees, [leaf] Some in here hondes bare boughes shene, [leaf] Some of laurer, and some of okes kene, [leaf] Some of hauthorne, and some of the woodbind, [leaf] And many mo which I hadde not in mind.

[letter: A] And so they came, here horses freshly stering [leaf] With bloodie sownes of her trompes loude; [leaf] There sie I many an uncouth disguising [leaf] In the array of these knightes proude; [leaf] And at the last, as evenly as they coude, [leaf] They took here places in middes of the mede, [leaf] And every knight turned his horse hede

[letter: T] To his fellow, & lightly laid a spere [leaf] In the arest; & so justes began [leaf] On every part abouten, here & there; [leaf] Some brake his spere, some drew down hors & manne; [leaf] Aboute the field astray the steedes ranne; [leaf] And, to behold here rule and governaunce, [leaf] I you ensure, it was a great pleasaunce.

[letter: A] And so the justes last an houre and more; [leaf] But tho that crowned were in laurer grene [leaf] Wanne the prise; here dintes were so sore, [leaf] That there was none ayenst hem mighte sustene: [leaf] And the justing all was yleft off clene, [leaf] And fro here horse the ninth alight anone, [leaf] And so did all the remnant everichone.

[letter: A] And forth they yede togider, twain and twain, [leaf] That to behold it was a worthy sight, [leaf] Toward the ladies on the greene plaine, [leaf] That song & daunced, as I saide now righte: [leaf] The ladies tho, soone as they goodly mighte, [leaf] They braken of bothe the song and dance, [leaf] And yede to meet hem with ful glad semblance.

[letter: A] And every lady tooke, full womanly, [leaf] By the right hond a knight, & forth they yede [leaf] Unto a faire laurer that stood fast by, [leaf] With leves lade, the boughes of great brede; [leaf] And to my dome there never was, indede, [leaf] Man that hadde seene halfe so faire a tree; [leaf] For underneath there might it well have be

[letter: A] An hundred persons, at here owne plesance, [leaf] Shadowed fro the heat of Phebus bright, [leaf] So that they shoulden have felt no grevaunce [leaf] Of raine ne haile that hem ne hurte mighte. [leaf] The savour eke rejoice would any wighte [leaf] That hadde be sicke or melancolius, [leaf] It was so very good and vertuous.

[letter: A] And with great reverence encline they lowe [leaf] To thilke tree so soot, and faire of hewe; [leaf] And after that, within a little throwe, [leaf] They beganne to singe and daunce of newe [leaf] Some song of love, some plaining of untrewe, [leaf] Envirouninge the tree that stood upright; [leaf] And ever yede a lady and a knight.

[Illustration]

[Illustration]

[letter: A] And at the last mine eye I caste aside, [leaf] And was ware of a lustie company [leaf] That came roming out of the field wide, [leaf] Hond in hond a knight

and a lady; [leaf] The ladies all in surcotes, that richely [leaf] Purfiled were with many a rich stone, [leaf] And every knight of grene ware mantles on,

[letter: E] Embrouded well so as the surcotes were: [leaf] And everich had a chapelet on her hede, [leaf] Which dide right well upon the shining here [leaf] I-made of goodly floures white and rede; [leaf] The knightes eke, that they in hond gan lede, [leaf] In sute of hem ware chapelets everychone, [leaf] And before hem wente minstrels many one.

[letter: A] As harpes, pipes, lutes, and sautry, [leaf] All in greene; and on here heades bare, [leaf] Of divers floures, made full craftely, [leaf] All in a sute, goodly chapelets they ware; [leaf] And, so dauncing, into the mede they fare. [leaf] In mid the which they found a tuft that was [leaf] Al oversprad with floures in compas.

[letter: W] Whereto they enclined everychone [leaf] With great reverence, and that full humbly; [leaf] And, at the laste, there began anone [leaf] A lady for to singe right womanly [leaf] A bargaret in praising the daisie; [leaf] For, as me thought, among her notes swete, [leaf] She said ‘Si douse est la Margarete.’

[letter: T] Than they all answered her in fere, [leaf] So passingly well, & so plesauntly, [leaf] That soth it was a blisfull noise to here. [leaf] But, I not how, it happede suddainly [leaf] As aboute noone, the sonne so fervently [leaf] Waxe hote, that the pretie tendre floures [leaf] Hadde lost the beautie of her freshe colours,

[letter: F] Forshronke with heat; the ladies eke to-brent, [leaf] That they ne wiste where hem to bestowe; [leaf] The knightes swelte, for lack of shade nie shent; [leaf] And after that, within a little throwe, [leaf] The wind began so sturdily to blowe, [leaf] That down goeth alle the floures everichone, [leaf] So that in all the mede there laft not one;

[letter: S] Save such as succoured were among the leves [leaf] Fro every storme that mighte hem assaile, [leaf] Growing under hedges and thicke greves; [leaf] And after that there came a storme of haile [leaf] And raine in fere, so that, withouten faile, [leaf] The ladies ne the knightes nade o threed [leaf] Drie upon hem, so dropping was her weed.

[letter: A] And whan the storm was cleane passed away, [leaf] Tho clad in white that stoode under the tree, [leaf] They felte nothing of the great affray, [leaf] That they in greene without had in ybe; [leaf] To hem they yede for routhe and pité, [leaf] Hem to comfort after here greate disease, [leaf] So faine they were the helplesse for to ease.

[letter: T] Than was I ware how one of hem in grene [leaf] Had on a crowne, ful rich and wel sitting; [leaf] Wherefore I demed wel she was a quene, [leaf] And tho in greene on her were awaiting; [leaf] The ladies then in white that were comming [leaf] Towardes hem, and the knightes in fere, [leaf] Beganne hem to comfort, and make hem chere.

[letter: T] The queen in white, that was of great beauty, [leaf] Tooke by the hond the queen that was in grene, [leaf] And said, ‘Suster, I have right great pitie [leaf] Of your annoy, and of the troublous tene, [leaf] Wherein ye and your company have bene

[leaf] So long, alas! and if that it you please [leaf] To go with me, I shall do you the ease,

[letter: I] In all the pleasure that I can or may;' [leaf] Whereof the tother, humbly as she mighte, [leaf] Thanked her; for in right ill array [leaf] She was with storm and heat, I you behighte; [leaf] And every lady, then anone right, [leaf] That were in white, one of hem took in grene [leaf] By the hond; which when the knightes hadde sene,

[letter: I] In like wise ech of hem tooke hir a knight [leaf] I-clad in greene, & forth with hem they fare, [leaf] Unto an hegge, where they anon gan right [leaf] To make here justes, woulde they not spare [leaf] Boughes to hewe down, and eke trees square, [leaf] Wherwith they made hem stately fires greate, [leaf] To dry here clothes that were wringing weate.

[letter: A] And after that, of hearbes that there grewe, [leaf] They made, for blisters of the sunne brenning, [leaf] Very good & wholesome ointmentes newe, [leaf] Where that they yede the sicke fast anointing; [leaf] And after that they yede aboute gadering [leaf] Pleasaunt salades, which they made hem eate, [leaf] For to refresh here greate unkindly heate.

[letter: T] The lady of the Leafe then gan to praye [leaf] Her of the Floure (for so to my seeming [leaf] They shoulde be, as by here arraye) [leaf] To soupe with her, & eek, for any thing, [leaf] That she shoulde with her all her people bringe; [leaf] And she ayen, in right goodly manere, [leaf] Thanketh her of her most friendly cheare,

[letter: S] Saying plainely, that she would obaye [leaf] With all her hart all her commaundement; [leaf] And then, anon, withoute lenger delaye, [leaf] The lady of the Leafe hath one ysent [leaf] For a palfray, as after her intent, [leaf] Arrayed well and faire in harneis of golde, [leaf] For nothing lacked, that to him long sholde.

[letter: A] And after that, to all her company [leaf] She made to purvey horse and every thing [leaf] That they needed; & then ful lustily, [leaf] Even by the herber where I was sitting, [leaf] They passed alle, so pleasantly singing, [leaf] That it would have comforted any wight. [leaf] But then I sie a passing wonder sight;

[letter: F] For then the nightingale, that all the day [leaf] Had in the laurer sete, & did her might [leaf] The whole service to singe longing to May, [leaf] All sodainly began to take her flight; [leaf] And to the lady of the Leafe, forthright, [leaf] She flew, and set her on her hond softly, [leaf] Which was a thing I marveled of greatly.

[letter: T] The goldfinch eke, that fro the medler tree [leaf] Was fled for heat into the bushes colde, [leaf] Unto the lady of the Flower gan flee, [leaf] And on her hond he set him as he wolde, [leaf] And pleasauntly his winges gan to folde; [leaf] And for to singe they pained hem both, as sore [leaf] As they hadde do of all the day before.

[letter: A] And so these ladies rode forth a great pace, [leaf] And all the rout of knightes eke in fere; [leaf] And I that hadde seene all this wonder case, [leaf] Thought I would assay in some manere, [leaf] To knowe fully the trouth of this matere; [leaf] And what they were that rode so pleasantly. [leaf] And when they were the herber passed by,

[letter: I] I dreste me forth, and happede to mete anone [leaf] Right a faire lady, I you ensure; [leaf] And she come riding by herselfe alone, [leaf] All in white; with semblance ful demure [leaf] I salued her, and bad her good aventure [leaf] Might her befall, as I coude most humbly; [leaf] And she answered, ‘My doughter, gramercy!’

[letter: M] ‘Madame,’ quod I, ‘if that I durst enquere [leaf] Of you, I woulde faine, of that company, [leaf] Wite what they be that paste by this arbere?’ [leaf] And she ayen answerede right friendly: [leaf] ‘My faire doughter, all tho that passed here by [leaf] In white clothing, be servaunts everichone [leaf] Unto the Leafe, and I myselfe am one.

[letter: S] See ye not her that crowned is,’ quod she, [leaf] ‘All in white?’—‘Madame,’ quod I, ‘yis:’ [leaf] ‘That is Diané, goddesse of chastité; [leaf] And for because that she a maiden is, [leaf] In her own hond the braunch she beareth iwis, [leaf] That agnus castus men calle properly; [leaf] And all the ladies in her company,

[letter: W] Which as ye se of that hearb chapelets weare, [leaf] Be such as han kept alway hir maidenheed: [leaf] And alle they that of laurer chapelets beare, [leaf] Be such as hardy were, and manly indeed, [leaf] Victorious name which never may be dede! [leaf] And alle they were so worthy of here honde, [leaf] That in her time none might hem withstonde.

[letter: A] And tho that weare chaplets on here hede [leaf] Of fresh woodbind, be such as never were [leaf] To love untrue in word, in thought, ne dede, [leaf] But aye stedfast; ne for pleasaunce, ne fere, [leaf] Thogh that they shuld here hertes al to-tere, [leaf] Woulde ne flitte, but ever were stedfaste, [leaf] Til that here lives there asunder braste.’

[letter: N] ‘Now faire madame,’ quod I, ‘yet would I pray [leaf] Your ladiship, if that it mighte be, [leaf] That I mighte knowe, by some maner way, [leaf] (Sith that it hath i-liked your beauté, [leaf] The trouth of these ladies for to telle me); [leaf] What that these knightes be in rich armour, [leaf] And what tho be in grene and weare the flour?

[letter: A] And why that some dide reverence to the tre, [leaf] And some unto the plot of floures faire?’ [leaf] ‘With right good will, my fair doghter,’ quod she, [leaf] ‘Sith your desire is good and debonaire; [leaf] Tho nine crowned be very exemplaire [leaf] Of all honour longing to chivalry; [leaf] And those certaine be called the Nine Worthy,

[letter: W] Which ye may see now riding all before [leaf] That in her time dide many a noble dede, [leaf] And for here worthinesse full oft have bore [leaf] The crowne of laurer leaves on here hede, [leaf] As ye may in your olde bookes rede; [leaf] And how that he that was a conquerour, [leaf] Hadde by laurer alway his most honour.

[letter: A] And tho that beare bowes in here honde [leaf] Of the precious laurer so notable, [leaf] Be such as were, I woll ye understonde, [leaf] Noble knightes of the rounde table, [leaf] And eke the Douseperis honourable, [leaf] Which they bearen in signe of victory; [leaf] It is witnesse of here deedes mightily.

[letter: E] Eke there be knightes old of the garter, [leaf] That in her time dide right worthily; [leaf] And the honour they dide to the laurer, [leaf] Is for by it they have here laud wholly, [leaf] Here triumph eke, and marshall glory; [leaf] Which unto hem is more parfit richesse, [leaf] Than any wight imagine can or gesse.

[letter: F] For one leafe given of that noble tree [leaf] To any wight that hath done worthily, [leaf] And it be done so as it oughte to be, [leaf] Is more honour than anything earthly; [leaf] Witnesse of Rome that founder was truly [leaf] Of all knighthood and deedes marvelous; [leaf] Record I take of Titus Livius.

[letter: A] And as for her that crowned is in greene, [leaf] It is Flora, of these floures goddesse; [leaf] And all that here on her awaiting beene, [leaf] It are such folk that loved idelnesse, [leaf] And not delite hadde of no businesse, [leaf] But for to hunt and hauke, and pley in medes, [leaf] And many other such idle dedes.

[letter: A] And for the greate delite and pleasaunce [leaf] They have to the floure, and so reverently [leaf] They unto it do such grete obeisaunce [leaf] As ye may se.'—'Now faire Madame,' quod I, [leaf] 'If I durst aske what is the cause and why, [leaf] That knightes have the signe of honour, [leaf] Wel rather by the leafe than by the flour?'

[letter: S] 'Soothly, doughter,' quod she, 'this is the trouth: [leaf] For knightes ever should be persevering, [leaf] To seeke honour without feintise or slouth, [leaf] Fro wele to better in all manner thing; [leaf] In signe of which, with leaves aye lasting [leaf] They be rewarded after here degré, [leaf] Whose lusty green may not appaired be,

[letter: B] But aie keping here beautie fresh & greene; For there nis storme that ne may hem deface, [leaf] Ne haile nor snow, ne winde nor frostes kene; [leaf] Wherfore they have this propertie and grace. And for the floure, within a little space [leaf] Woll be i-lost, so simple of nature [leaf] They be, that they no greevance may endure;

[letter: A] And every storme will blow hem soone awaye, [leaf] Ne laste they not but for oon season; That is the cause, the very trouth to saye, [leaf] That they maye not, by no way of reason, [leaf] Be put to no such occupation.' [leaf] 'Madame,' quod I, 'with all mine whole servise [leaf] I thanke you now, in my most humble wise;

[letter: F] For now I am acertained throughly, [leaf] Of every thing I desired to knowe.' [leaf] 'I am right glad that I have said, sothly, [leaf] Ought to your pleasure, if ye wille me trowe,' [leaf] Quod she ayen, 'but to whom do ye owe [leaf] Your service? and which wolle ye honoure, [leaf] Tel me I pray, this yere, the Leafe or the Floure?'

[letter: M] 'Madame,' quod I, 'though I be least worthy, [leaf] Unto the Leafe I owe mine observaunce': 'That is,' quod she, 'right well done certainly; And pray I God to honour you avaunce, [leaf] And kepe you fro the wicked remembraunce [leaf] Of Malebouch, and all his crueltie, [leaf] And all that good and well conditioned be.

[letter: F] For here may I no lenger now abide, [leaf] I muste followe the greate company, [leaf] That ye maye see yonder before you ride.' And tho forth, as I couthe, most humbly, [leaf] I tooke my leve of her, as she gan hie [leaf] After hem as fast as ever she mighte; [leaf] And I drow homeward, for it was nigh nighte,

[letter: A] And put all that I hadde seene in writing, [leaf] Under support of hem that lust it to rede. [leaf] O little booke, thou art so unconning, [leaf] How darst thou put thyself in prees, for drede? [leaf] It is wonder that thou wexest not rede! [leaf] Sith that thou wost full lite who shall beholde [leaf] Thy rude language, ful boistously unfolde.

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